

CHAPTER THREE

News values

1 Introduction

In Chapter 1 we mentioned ethnographic research that suggests that news values have a huge impact on the process of reporting and editing news. This chapter provides an introduction to this important concept, illustrating it with manifold authentic examples from English-language news discourse. These examples are taken from Bednarek (2006c), Bednarek and Caple (2010), and our dataset, as well as three additional stories (Weisman and Meckler 2008, Kwek et al. 2011, Sands 2011). Our objectives are to enable readers to understand:

- what news values are and the different ways in which they have been defined
- what different news values we can distinguish
- how news values are construed through discourse (language and image).

We will start by outlining news values as they have been theorized by media researchers and linguists. Then we introduce our own approach, which looks at the construal of news values both linguistically and photographically. Finally, we illustrate this *discursive* approach with authentic examples of news discourse.

2 What are news values?

News values have primarily been described in terms of the factors that take an event into the news. According to Galtung and Ruge (1965) an event has to cross a certain threshold before it will be registered as news. This threshold has been theorized in media studies as ‘news values’. In a first

definition, news values can thus be described as the ‘values by which one “fact” is judged more newsworthy than another’ (Bell 1991: 155). However, *news values* have been variously defined as:

- the **criteria** or **rules** that news workers apply to determine what is ‘news’ (Bell 1991: 155, Richardson 2007: 91, Brighton and Foy 2007: 1)
- ‘the (*imagined*) **preferences** of the expected audience’ (Richardson 2007: 94, italics in original, bold face ours) about what is newsworthy
- the **values** by which events or facts are judged more newsworthy than others (Galtung and Ruge 1965, Hartley 1982, Fowler 1991, Tunstall 1996), shared both by producers and audiences of news discourse (van Dijk 1988b: 119)
- the **qualities/elements** that are necessary to make a story newsworthy (Cotter 2010: 68).

What these different definitions have in common, however, is that news values are said to determine what makes something newsworthy – worthy of being news. Since the classic study by Galtung and Ruge (1965) on Scandinavian news discourse, varying lists of such values have been suggested by researchers (cf. Bell 1991: 156–60, Brighton and Foy 2007, Richardson 2007: 92, Cotter 2010: 69).¹ However, the kinds of concepts that researchers list as *news values* are clearly not of the same kind (see also Harcup and O’Neill 2001, cited in Richardson 2007: 92) and it is questionable whether or not they should all be covered by the same term. For example, according to Bell’s (1991) classification, there are three classes of news values: (1) values in the news text, (2) values in the news process, (3) values in news actors and events. However, these differ quite considerably from each other. For example, Bell’s **values in the news text** – brevity, clarity, colour – are more like general characteristics demanded of a news story in order to be included. We will call these three ‘values’ *news writing objectives* (cf. Chapter 4). Bell’s **values in the news process** are factors that impact on the selection of news. These include the following:

- continuity (once a story appears as news it continues as news)
- competition (the competition among news institutions for scoops, the competition among stories for coverage)
- co-option (associating one story with a more newsworthy one)
- composition (the mix of different kinds of stories in the overall news bulletin or newspaper)
- predictability (the scheduling of events, such as press conferences to fit the news cycle)
- prefabrication (the existence of prefabricated input sources – see Chapter 2).

We will call these ‘values’ *news cycle/market factors*. For example, sometimes photographers may capture a moment in the unfolding of an event that others miss or ignore. Thus, having a photograph or footage that no other news organization has (an exclusive) can get a story into the news. Cotter also notes that factors **other than newsworthiness** that influence the production of news include ‘availability of space, the amount of news occurring on a particular day, a balance or mix of types of news . . . , the time to deadline . . . , day of the week . . . , the audience or readership . . . and the focus . . . of the news outlet’ (2010: 80).

Table 3.1 Categorizing news ‘values’

Bell’s (1991) Categories	Our Categories
Values in the news text	News writing objectives
Values in the news process	News cycle/market factors
Values in news actors and events	News values

As we believe that the three different categories that Bell distinguishes are very different in kind (Table 3.1), we only use the term *news values* for Bell’s **values in news actors and events**, later offering two perspectives on such values. However, it is important to keep in mind that other researchers often use the term *news values* to include what we call *news writing objectives* and *news cycle/market factors*.

Table 3.2 News values summary

Negativity	Negative aspects of an event
Timeliness	The relevance of the event in terms of time
Proximity	The geographical and/or cultural nearness of the event
Prominence	The high status of the individuals (e.g. celebrities, politicians), organizations or nations involved in the event, including quoted sources
Consonance	The extent to which aspects of a story fit in with stereotypes that people may hold about the events and people portrayed in it
Impact	The effects or consequences of an event
Novelty	The unexpected aspects of an event
Superlativeness	The maximized or intensified aspects of an event
Personalization	The personal or human interest aspects of an event

For us then, news values relate to the events as reported in news stories and to the news actors involved in the events as reported in the news story (see further below on our *discursive perspective*). They are the values that make the story newsworthy. These values include but are not limited to Negativity, Timeliness, Proximity, Prominence, Consonance, Impact, Novelty, Superlativeness, Personalization (Table 3.2 on p. 41). We will now discuss each news value in turn.

Negativity: negative aspects of an event

News stories very frequently concern ‘bad’ happenings such as conflicts, accidents, damage, injuries, disasters or wars. Negativity is therefore sometimes called ‘the basic news value’ (Bell 1991: 156), and a common adage by news workers is ‘if it bleeds, it leads’. On the other hand, good news also occurs, for example, the downward trend of malaria as detailed in the World malaria report 2010, which featured in news stories throughout the English-speaking world (e.g. Malaria control ‘best in decades’: WHO 2010). Feez et al. (2008: 72) argue that newsworthiness is in essence about reporting both ‘destabilizing’ (negative) and ‘stabilizing’ (positive) events. Conboy also mentions the ‘feelgood’ stories of the popular press (2002: 174) and we can find ‘alternative’ newspapers such as *Positive News* (www.positivenews.org.uk, last accessed 21 September 2011) that emphasize the positive over the negative.

Timeliness: the relevance of the event in terms of time

More recent events are often more newsworthy: ‘the best news is something which has only just happened’ (Bell 1991: 156). But timeliness may also mean that particular seasonal events are newsworthy, such as stories about Christmas in the pre-Christmas period. Given that timeliness in general is about how an event is temporally relevant to the reader (as opposed to, say, culturally relevant, see ‘Proximity’), Timeliness can be associated with aspects of an event that only just (e.g. yesterday) happened, that are still ongoing (e.g. breaking news) or that will happen in the (near) future.

Proximity: the geographical and/or cultural nearness of the event

What is newsworthy usually concerns the country, region or city in which the news is published. As Rau puts it in the context of Australian news, in terms of news value ‘one person dead in Australia equates to fifty in Britain and 500 in a developing country’ (2010: 13). Britain is more newsworthy in Australia than in some other countries because of its history, as well as the similarity of the cultures – what Galtung and Ruge (1965) call meaningfulness (see also Bell 1991: 157). In the United States, the journalistic community ‘prioritizes “local” news over international or other types of *cognitively distant* news’ (Cotter 2010: 49,

italics in original). So Proximity includes both geographical and cultural nearness.

Prominence/eliteness: the high status of the individuals (e.g. celebrities, politicians), organizations or nations involved in the event, including quoted sources

Stories about ‘elite’ individuals or celebrities are more newsworthy than stories about ordinary people, and sources that are affiliated with an organization or institution or are otherwise officially recognized authorities are preferred over others: ‘The more elite the source, the more newsworthy the story’ (Bell 1991: 192). Prominence of sources is sometimes given its own news value label, Attribution.

Consonance: the extent to which aspects of a story fit in with stereotypes that people may hold about the events and people portrayed in it

Aspects of a story become newsworthy if they tie in with the stereotypes that people hold (e.g. about a certain news actor such as Paris Hilton and her typical behaviour). This can also relate to people’s stereotypes about organizations, institutions or countries: Richardson (2007: 93) mentions a study by the Glasgow Media Group that showed that the coverage of TV news about developing countries focused on negative events such as war, terrorism, disaster and conflict. While this kind of reporting may be in line with the general news value of Negativity (see above), it might also be interpreted more critically as presenting a narrow preconceived view of these countries.

Impact: the effects or consequences of an event

The effects or consequences of an event are aspects of a story that are newsworthy, especially, if they involve serious repercussions or have a more global impact, rather than only minor consequences. Environmental stories frequently feature descriptions of the (negative – see ‘Negativity’) effects of environmental happenings (Bednarek and Caple 2010). Aspects that can be seen to affect the audience’s lives, that are ‘relevant’ (van Dijk 1988b: 122) to them, are especially newsworthy (Bell 1991: 157–8).

Novelty/deviance/unusuality/rarity/surprise: the unexpected aspects of an event

News stories are frequently about happenings that surprise us, that are unusual or rare. News workers may even specifically label certain content in such a way: for example, a Reuters online news gallery might be titled ‘Strange and unusual’ (www.reuters.com/news/pictures/slideshow?articleId=USRTXVSQ1#a=1, last accessed 21 December 2010) and the website of the UK tabloid the *Daily Mirror* features a news subsection called ‘Weird

World' (www.mirror.co.uk/news/weird-world/, last accessed 21 December 2010).

Superlativeness: the maximized or intensified aspects of an event

Generally speaking, the news value of Superlativeness says that the bigger, the faster, the more destructive, the more violent, the more famous . . . the more newsworthy something is. Thus, news stories usually focus on maximizing or intensifying particular aspects of an event, say the amount of people it involved, the consequences it has or might have, the numbers mentioned, the size of things, the force of actions, the intensity of behaviour, and so on.

Personalization: the personal or human interest aspects of an event

News stories that are personalized attract audiences more than the portrayal of generalized concepts or processes. For example, a science story can be made more newsworthy if it directly impacts on a news actor who is willing to tell their story. Eyewitness accounts, for example, of survivors, also clearly increase news value. Personalization is thus about the many ways in which a human face is given to the news.

3 News values: cognitive or discursive?

What is the relationship between the above-mentioned news values, the news event, the news workers involved and the news story? In this book, we will make a distinction between a more 'cognitive' view of news values and a more 'discursive' view of news values. From a **cognitive** perspective we can conceptualize news values as beliefs (or criteria), 'intersubjective mental categories' (Fowler 1991: 17) or '*internalized assumptions*' (Cotter 2010: 56, italics in original) that people hold/apply about qualities/aspects that make something newsworthy. For example, a news worker can believe that a news story is newsworthy because it features Prince William, an 'elite' social actor or because the event concerns the deaths of many people from their own country. Such beliefs about newsworthiness may at times vary according to the individuals concerned: '[E]very journalist and every editor will have a different interpretation of what is newsworthy, because it's such a subjective process' (Rau 2010: 14).

From a **discursive** perspective, we can conceptualize news values in terms of how newsworthiness is construed through discourse (both language and image). Newsworthiness is not inherent in events but established through language and image. In the following example for instance,

A family uses a makeshift raft to get about in Ayuttaya province, 80 kilometres north of Thailand's capital, Bangkok, as **the worst** monsoon floods in **more than a decade** sweep through Thailand and Burma.

(‘Hell on high water’, *Sydney Morning Herald*, 12 October 2006, p. 11)

the comparison in bold (*worst . . . in more than a decade*) simultaneously construes the news values of Superlativeness, Negativity and Novelty. From a discursive perspective then, we ask the following question: what is it in the language/image that construes or establishes an event as newsworthy – what aspects of news discourse function to construe/establish the newsworthiness of an event? This question can be asked both when considering the potential of language and image to do so (cf. Sections 4 and 5) and when analysing actual news discourse (cf. Section 6).

In other words, the focus here is not on the ‘nature’ of news events, but rather on how such events are **mediated** through language and image – how news discourse **makes them newsworthy**. From this perspective, news values are not ‘inherent’ aspects of events or internalized beliefs, they are values that are established by language and image in use.

Because of these two dimensions of news values (cognitive and discursive),² it is possible to establish lists of news values both on the basis of interviewing news workers such as editors or journalists about what they believe is newsworthy as well as by deriving news values from analysing news stories themselves. It is also important to point out that the two perspectives are not separate, nor are they mutually exclusive. For example, when making judgements about newsworthiness, news workers often work with linguistic construals of events such as press releases, and so on (see Chapter 2 for input sources) which may already include a particular discursive construal of how the event is newsworthy. Further, beliefs about and linguistic construals of newsworthiness interact: News workers

Figure 3.1 News values, the communicative context and the construction of text

have assumptions about what is newsworthy, about what audiences find newsworthy and this may influence (consciously or not) their construction of newsworthiness through discourse. Arguably, the text or news discourse itself is intended to attract an audience through presenting a story to them that is newsworthy (Figure 3.1 on p. 45).

This also explains the variation of news values across media (e.g. popular vs quality press): what is newsworthy to one group of readers is not necessarily newsworthy to another. It is the discursive aspect of news values that we are interested in the most in this book, and that we will discuss in the next two sections of this chapter – first language, then images.

4 News values and language

How, then, does language construe news value, and what are the linguistic devices that may be used? In fact, most editing changes made to input material are ‘designed to maximize news value’ (Bell 1991: 79). The examples Bell gives include changing the structure of the story to foreground more newsworthy aspects as well as cutting and lexical substitution to make a story more newsworthy, for example, through emphasizing the authority of sources or through the use of stronger vocabulary. So let us first look at some of the main kinds of linguistic devices that can be used to construe news values (as defined above).

Evaluative language

Evaluative language includes linguistic expressions that realize opinion, for example, assessments of positivity or negativity, importance or unimportance, expectedness or unexpectedness (cf. Chapter 6). Negative evaluations of events (*fiasco*), behaviour (*cashes in*, *made a gaffe*) or news actors (*sexual predator*, *wannabe*), clearly construe the news value of Negativity. Evaluations of new actors and sources as important (*celebs*, *famous*, *superstars*, *senior*, *top*) construe Prominence, while the evaluation of events as significant (*key*, *vital*, *historic*, *momentous*) can construe Impact (e.g. *a historic legal case*, *a potentially momentous day*). Other examples include the use of words like *amazing*, *astonishing*, *extraordinarily*, *curious*, *unexpectedly*, *unprecedented*, *unusually* or contrasts (e.g. *but*, *although*, *despite*) to construe Novelty. Meanings of unexpectedness which construe news value can also be encoded in certain expressions used to report information, such as *reveal* or *revelation*, which imply that the reported information is somehow new. In contrast, the use of expressions like *routine*, *familiar*, *little wonder* may construe Consonance. Generally, the function of evaluative devices is ‘to make the contents of the story sound *as X as possible*, where X is big, recent, important, unusual, new; in a word – newsworthy’ (Bell 1991: 152, italics

in original). For extensive discussion of these and other examples see also Bednarek (2006c, 2010a).

Intensification and quantification

Linguistic means of intensification and quantification include devices to intensify number or amount (*thousands of*), size (*huge waves, peanut-size hail*), duration and extent of time (*rapidly rising, continuous rain*), force (*ferocious storm, ravage, blaze*) or degree (*full fury, complete destruction*), including comparative and superlative adjectives (*the most violent type, hardest hit, the largest*). These construe Superlativeness and can be used to maximize any aspect of the reported event. Also common in construing Superlativeness in the news are expressions with the adverbs *only/just/alone* used to modify time and space: *took only a few seconds, just hours after, just three days before, in the past two months alone, just 10 miles from*.³ At times, it is specifically the effects or consequences of an event that are maximized – for example, when mentioning that as a result of flooding, *There have been massive landslides nearby*. In such cases, we can reasonably argue that both Superlativeness and Impact are established.

Comparison

Happenings in a news story are often compared to similar happenings in the past. This frequently functions to construe Novelty, when the current event is described as, say, the first of its kind or for a long time (e.g. *the first time since 1958*). Figure 3.2 shows all instances of *first* in a news story about the election of Barack Obama as US president in 2008, clearly showing how Novelty is a key news value in this report (this story is discussed in more detail in Appendix 2).

Figure 3.2 Concordance lines demonstrating Novelty in a news story on the election of Barack Obama

However, such comparisons can also function to construe Consonance, if an event is said to be very much in line with past events, for example, talking about *yet another personal scandal* for former Italian Prime Minister Silvio Berlusconi. Finally, when aspects of an event are specifically said to be bigger/higher/more forceful . . . than a previous event, this may function

to establish both Superlativeness and Novelty (e.g. *this one has just maxed out every other flood*).

References to emotion

References to emotion, that is, describing news actors' emotional responses, can take many forms, for example, describing 'emotional' behaviour such as screaming or shouting or labelling emotions (Martin and White 2005, Bednarek 2008a).⁴ Examples of such references to emotions are: *'There are others inside' she screamed; Deborah sobbed to the jury; Di's terror; British madam distraught; devastated Rio; Police chiefs shocked; anxious Iraqis*. Such references can construe a variety of news values ranging from Negativity (negative emotions) to Personalization (individuals' emotional responses), Impact (when the emotions are caused by an event), Superlativeness ('strong' emotions such as *desperate, panic, terror, . . .*) and Novelty (references to surprise, for example, *note that will stun world*). Similar to mentions of surprise, references to expectation (strictly speaking, not an emotional response) also establish Novelty (e.g. *no one was expecting it*).

'Negative' vocabulary

'Negative' vocabulary (e.g. *confusion, damage, deaths, bodies*) refers to the words we use to describe negative events. They have also been described as 'disaster vocabulary' (Ungerer 1997: 315). In contrast to evaluative language, such vocabulary does not automatically and expressly tell us that the writer disapproves of the reported events and is thus not strictly evaluative language. References to the negative effects/impact on individuals, entities, and so on are used to construe both Negativity and Impact (e.g. *flash flood deluged the town*.) The news value that is construed by negative vocabulary is usually Negativity, since we can assume that when a story reports upon the deaths (killings, etc.) of people this is regarded as a 'bad' happening by most. However, consider Figure 3.3, where we would argue that the use of negative vocabulary (*dead, killed, die*) certainly does not construe the event as a negative one from the point of view of these newspapers (and probably many of their readers) – as shown through the use of negative evaluative language (*the bastard, evil, coward*) – and where the event is construed as

Figure 3.3 Front pages on the killing of Osama bin Laden

justice or righteous *vengeance*. Indeed, the Poynter website, which features a collection of 45 bin Laden front pages from around the world, uses the heading ‘Newspaper front pages capture **elation, relief** that Osama bin Laden **was killed**’ (Moos 2011, bold face ours).

So such negative vocabulary needs to be considered in its context – when negative things happen to ‘people like us’ or ‘people we like’, Negativity is construed, but otherwise this may not be the case. We can also include in the category of negative vocabulary the use of labels for socially defined negative behaviour, for instance, *offence* or *crime*. These can be regarded as originating not in the speaker but in ‘the institutionalised legal process’ (White 1998: 131).

Before we continue with our discussion of resources for construing news values, it may be worth taking a step back to look at an example that illustrates some of the above points:

The world’s best triathletes imposed themselves on Sydney yesterday for all the wrong reasons after mass road closures turned the city into a gridlocked nightmare.

The day began with super fit athletes chasing each other around the Opera House, Harbour Bridge and harbour, and ended with thousands of frustrated motorists cursing the fallout from their efforts.

(‘Triathletes reduce city traffic to an Australian crawl’, *Sydney Morning Herald*, 11 April 2011, p. 1)

These are the first two sentences of a news story about a triathlon in Sydney, an event that arguably could have been reported in many different ways. In this particular instance, we can see that evaluative language (*wrong, a gridlocked nightmare, imposed themselves on*), references to negative emotions (*frustrated motorists, cursing*) and negative vocabulary (*road closures, fallout*) all emphasize the news value of Negativity. In addition, the use of intensification/quantification (*the world’s best, mass road closures, super fit, thousands of*) construes Prominence (of the athletes), Superlativeness and Impact. Thus, this event (the triathlon) has been **made newsworthy** through emphasizing the eliteness of its participants and maximizing negative consequences. There is nothing ‘inherently’ negative about a triathlon; rather news workers have deployed linguistic resources to make the event more interesting, more newsworthy to their audience (many of whom would commute by car to and from the city). We will now look at further linguistic resources that can be used to this effect.

Word combinations

Certain words are repeatedly combined, or associated with each other to invoke stereotypes or scripts, thus establishing Consonance. For example, Table 3.3 shows the results for a search of words associated with commonly

Table 3.3 Associations with Australia

Search Terms	www.thetimes.co.uk/	www.usatoday.com/
Australia shark	1,869	316
Australia spider	199	317
Australia crocodile	351	56
Australia surfing	358	193
Australia surfer	303	31
Australia drunk	635	69

held beliefs about Australia from two newspaper websites (search results pertain to the whole website, not just news stories).

Most frequent on *The Times* website are associations of Australia with sharks, drinking, surfing and crocodiles, whereas the most frequent associations on the *USA Today* website are with spiders, sharks and surfing. Sharks and surfing seem to be commonly associated with Australia both in the United Kingdom and in the United States, and invoked in mentions of Australia on newspaper websites, arguably drawing on commonly held associations by the audience and construing Consonance. A corpus linguistic investigation of collocations, clusters and concordances (Baker 2006) can help us show the typical associations of words/concepts tied to Consonance.

Metaphor/simile

The terms *metaphor* and *simile* refer to the way one concept is seen in terms of another – either implicitly through metaphor (*a wall of water*) or more explicitly through simile (*like a World War II battle*). News stories can and do make use again and again of common or conventionalized metaphors to construe Consonance. For example, Fairclough (1995) (though not discussing it in terms of news values) notes that a *Sun* article’s use of the metaphor of fighting a war in the context of drug trafficking ‘links this text *intertextually* to popular media coverage of the drugs issue over a long period, where the representation of the issue as a war . . . is a standard feature of the discourse’ (Fairclough 1995: 71, italics in original). Other common practices include the frequent application of ‘liquid’ (often water) metaphors to the movement of refugees, for example, *the flood of refugees*, *refugees are streaming home*, *overflowing refugee camps*, with refugees being ‘constructed as a “natural disaster” like a flood, which is difficult to control as it has no sense of its own agency’ (Baker 2006: 81). News

texts often address ‘an ideal interpreter who is familiar with a particular preconstructed “script” (Montgomery et al. 1989) that is being evoked’ (Fairclough 1995: 123). Aside from Consonance, metaphors also function to establish Superlativeness (e.g. describing a flood as *a brown wall of water*), as do certain similes (e.g. *thunderstorms that looked like the apocalypse*).

Story structure

The way a news story is structured, the roles the news actors are construed to play and the events that are said to have happened may fit in with archetypes of stories (e.g. ‘hero’, ‘villain’, ‘rescue’), thereby construing Consonance: ‘When you enjoy a story, you are experiencing an echo, or particular realisation, of other stories you already know (and which give rise to expectations about the one you are experiencing at the time)’ (Durant and Lambrou 2009: 34). The structure of news story narratives will be fully discussed in Chapter 4, but again, we can take a step back at this stage to briefly consider another example.

Thirsty foreigners soak up scarce water rights

International investors are circling Australia’s water market, looking to snap up hundreds of millions of dollars worth of our most precious national resource, with almost no government limit on how much they can buy.

(‘Thirsty foreigners soak up scarce water rights’, *Sydney Morning Herald*, 4–5 September 2010, p. 1)

In this extract we can very clearly see how an at first glance ‘boring’ event concerning water rights has been made newsworthy through a juxtaposition of ‘Australians’ (*Australia’s, our*) with ‘foreigners’ (*thirsty foreigners, international investors*). These ‘foreigners’ are associated with a predator metaphor (sharks circle) and represented as the agents of negative actions (*soak up scarce water rights, circling Australia’s water market, looking to snap up our most precious national resource*) with Australia and its water rights/market being the victim. A predator–victim construal of the narrative suggests itself here, which is arguably in line with many people’s negative assumptions about foreign investment in a country’s natural resources and ties in with a commonly used narrative about threats from the outside. Intensification/quantification (*hundreds of millions of dollars, most precious, no government limit*) further heightens the inherent danger in these ‘circling thirsty foreigners’ but also evaluates the Australian government negatively (because they have set no limit). Thus, news workers have again deployed linguistic resources carefully to make an event interesting and newsworthy through Negativity and Superlativeness. Let us consider resources for other news values now.

References to time and place

References to time and place establish Timeliness and Proximity usually through adverbs (*yesterday, currently*), nominal groups/phrases (*this week, this year, last week, last night, the weekend's, Wellington researchers, Canadian soldiers, the wind-swept shores of Lake Ontario, the National Stadium, their home in Washington, a Baltimore county democrat*) or prepositional phrases (*near the Royal Albert Hall in central London; at Eden Park; in London's Leicester Square; in parts of the country; in Connact, Ulster and Leinster; at Arlington National Cemetery*) realizing adverbials/circumstances of time and place. Timeliness can also be construed through verb tense (and aspect) – past, present and future. Regarding the latter, references to future events have been said to fulfil two functions: to increase timeliness and to place something on the news agenda (Jaworski et al. 2003: 64).

References to the nation/community

Related to references to time and place are references that quite explicitly address local or national communities. In this way, the relevance of the event for this community (Proximity) is established. For instance, in the context of reporting a local disaster, a quote may in fact tie this to the national context, thereby establishing a larger community and a higher level of relevance: *The Prime Minister warned **the nation** it must brace for more deaths*. We can also find phrases such as *Local veterans tell us their story* where the adjective *local* construes Proximity for a specific community.

First-person plural pronouns

Using first-person plural pronouns (*we, our*, etc.) establishes Proximity both culturally and geographically, but only if the pronoun includes the audience (as in the water rights story above: ***our** most precious national resource*). For example, a quote by an eyewitness that refers to the actions that he and a group of others undertook to save others (*'We went into the waters to try to find a safe way to get to them'*) does not construe Proximity, but a quote by a politician who refers to the way an event affects not just her but the whole community or even nation (*'It might be breaking **our** hearts at the moment, but it will not break **our** will'*) does.

Role labels

Role labels are used to describe the roles, titles or professions of people. The Prominence of news actors and sources, including their professional role, title and affiliation is usually construed through descriptive noun phrases (for their syntactic structures see Bell 1991, Jucker 1992) such as: *England manager Sven Goran Eriksson; the Tory leader; two Premiership footballers; the Sinn Fein president, Commonwealth Bank CEO Ralph*

Norris; ACCC [Australian Competition and Consumer Commission] chairman Graeme Samuel; Carroll County Circuit Judge Michael M. Galloway; former Alaska Gov. Sarah Palin. Sometimes such noun phrases also include evaluative vocabulary or comparison indicating importance (e.g. *top* psychologist Dr Peter Kindermann; *Supt* Martin Harding, *the most senior black officer in GMP*).

Quotes from 'ordinary' individuals

Quoting what news actors, more specifically, what 'ordinary' as opposed to 'elite' actors say, construes Personalization, rendering an issue personal as we get to hear their view or how it has impacted them, for example: *But one of his victims, who can only be identified as Deborah, sobbed as she said afterwards: 'My sentence has only just begun.'* Hearing from the 'man or woman on the street' (*vox pop*) means we can relate to the quote more than when 'elite' sources (e.g. the prime minister) speaks and it renders the issue personal. However, when elite speakers comment on the experience of individuals this may well contribute to Personalization. An example of this is New Zealand Prime Minister John Key's reported comment on the 2011 earthquake affecting Christchurch: "*People are just sitting on the side of the road, their heads in their hands. This is a community that is absolutely in agony,*" Key said.' Here Key's quote clearly construes Personalization by referring to people's and the community's emotional reactions (see 'References to emotion' above).

References to individuals

References to individuals and their experiences can construe Personalization, framing a bigger issue with a personal slant. For example, a story on airfares and the air industry in the *Miami Herald* starts with references to individuals and their story:

In the 10 years they have been together, Charissa Benjamin and her Serbian husband have always flown from their home in Washington to spend the winter holidays in her native Antigua. But with the lowest economy-class fare this year advertised at about \$1,500 – more than twice the \$700 she paid in 2009 – Benjamin is considering ringing in 2011 with her husband's family in decidedly chillier Belgrade. Flights there cost half as much as those to the Caribbean. ('Passengers face sticker shock as airfares soar', *Miami Herald*, International edition, 10 November 2010, p. 1)

Identifying a specific person by name (e.g. *Charissa Benjamin*) is arguably more personalizing than referring to individuals by a more generic label such as *passengers*. There are various ways in which references to 'ordinary' people can be made, including variations in the use of proper

names (e.g. first name, last name, full name, use of titles), the inclusion of social categories (such as age, gender, ethnicity, sexual orientation, religion, etc.), reference to roles (teacher, doctor, victim), kinship relations (husband, mother) or physical characteristics (blonde, tall) (van Leeuwen 2008: 40–5). Frequently such information is provided in a ‘quasi-title’ (Bell 1991: 196) nominal structure such as *estranged husband Captain Mark Phillips*, or *former colleague Colin Wallace* which apes the titles of elite actors and ‘embodies the claim of the ordinary person or the newly elite to news fame’ (Bell 1991: 196).

* * *

Before we discuss in further detail the relationship between linguistic devices and news values, Table 3.4 on pp. 55–6 provides a summary of the above-listed devices (see also Table A1.1 in Appendix 1).

As has become apparent, there are manifold linguistic devices that can be used to establish newsworthiness. It is important at this stage to point out that there is no one-to-one relationship between these devices and the news values they construe. First, the same linguistic feature can construe more than one news value. For example, the use of a metaphor such as *the flood of refugees* may construe both Superlativeness (because it increases the amount of refugees) and Consonance (because it is a commonly used metaphor). Frequently, references to the impact of an event concern effects/consequences that are **negative**, and thus construe both Impact and Negativity, and when they are furthermore intensified, they also construe Superlativeness. All three news values are clearly construed in the following reference to the effects of the floods in Queensland, Australia, in early 2011 (through use of negative vocabulary and intensification describing their consequences): *Drivers were washed away in their cars, a house was swept off its foundations, a railway line was suspended in midair and a shipping container ripped up roads as the rushing waters savaged Toowoomba, Lockyer Valley, Grantham and Murphys Creek in just one hour*. In fact, there may be a case for arguing that certain linguistic devices feature so frequently in news discourse because they can simultaneously construe more than one news value and hence contribute significantly to rendering the story newsworthy, and to attracting readers. References to emotion are a case in point with their potential to establish Negativity, Personalization, Novelty, Impact and Superlativeness.

Secondly, when we analyse news discourse for linguistic devices that establish newsworthiness, we should proceed carefully and use a functional approach. Rather than, say, identifying all direct quotes and assigning them to the news value of Personalization, we need to take into consideration the likely function of the direct quote – only if it can reasonably be interpreted as functioning to construe Personalization should it be included in the analysis. To give another example, not all references to time within a story

Table 3.4 Summary of linguistic resources that can be used to construe news values

Linguistic Device	News Value	Examples
Evaluative language	Negativity Prominence Impact Novelty Consonance	<i>terrible news, a tragedy pop star, celebrity bad boy a potentially momentous day a very different sort of disaster legendary, notorious</i>
References to emotion	Negativity Impact Novelty Personalization Superlativeness	<i>distraught, worried, breaking our hearts A terror that took their breath away shocked residents 'It was pretty bloody scary' they were petrified</i>
Negative vocabulary	Negativity	<i>killed, deaths, bodies</i>
References to time	Timeliness	<i>The Prime Minister today warned, yesterday's flash flooding</i>
Verb tense and aspect	Timeliness	<i>rescuers have been trying to pluck survivors, it's a tragedy, more to come, it is testing our emergency resources, residents have described the horrific moments when they faced a brown wall of water</i>
References to place	Proximity	<i>Queensland, Brisbane, Canberra, Queensland's residents</i>
References to the nation/community	Proximity	<i>it will test us as a community The Prime Minister warned the nation it must brace for more deaths</i>
First-person plural pronouns (inclusive)	Proximity	<i>It might be breaking our hearts at the moment, but it will not break our will</i>
Intensification and quantification	Superlativeness Impact	<i>a giant torrent, a tragedy of epic proportions the . . . storm . . . dumped 100 mm of rain in his gauge in just 30 minutes Power has been cut to thousands of Queensland's residents the rushing waters savaged Toowoomba</i>
Metaphor	Superlativeness Consonance	<i>an army of volunteers, a brown wall of water a flood of immigrants</i>

Contd.

Table 3.4 Contd.

Linguistic Device	News Value	Examples
Simile	Superlativeness	<i>our Queens Park was like a raging river, it was like a World War II battle</i>
Role labels	Prominence	<i>The Prime Minister, Queensland Premier Anna Bligh, Professor Roger Stone</i>
References to effects/ impact on individuals, entities, and so on	Impact	<i>overwhelming volumes of water . . . wrecking families and their fortunes flash flood deluged the town leaving scenes of destruction</i>
Comparison	Novelty Consonance Superlativeness	<i>I've lived in Toowoomba for 20 years and I've never seen anything like that yet another personal scandal this one has just maxed out every other flood</i>
Quotes from 'ordinary' people	Personalization	<i>'Myself, I was almost pulled in by the torrent'</i>
References to individuals	Personalization	<i>Panel-beater Colin McNamara</i>
Repeated word combinations	Consonance	<i>Australia – sharks</i>
Story structure	Consonance	N/A

construe Timeliness, some simply establish the temporal flow within the story (e.g. *after, as, meanwhile*).

Thirdly, the various linguistic devices that construe newsworthiness may not occur throughout a news story but may cluster in specific parts – we will look at this further in Chapter 4, and there are also other ways of attracting and engaging with audiences that are less obviously tied to newsworthiness, for instance, the use of word play (e.g. *People smugglers go fishing for a new ploy*), allusions (*George Michael jailed for drug-driving crash as magistrate finally loses the faith*) or direct questions in headlines (e.g. *But can you afford to plug it in?*) or, on a macro-level the undertaking of newspaper campaigns (Richardson 2007). Again, we will look at some of these linguistic characteristics of news discourse in Chapter 4.

Finally, the systematic analysis of the discursive construal of news values is still in its infancy and there may be additional devices that will be

identified as key resources for construing newsworthiness. While research has certainly recognized that ‘The language of a news story is . . . adapted to *highlight* its newsworthiness’ (Durant and Lambrou 2009: 89, italics in original), there have been few attempts to explicitly link specific devices to news values (with only some comments in, for example, Bell 1991, Bednarek 2006c). This is all the more true with regard to news images and news values, as discussed in the following section.

5 News values and image

As indicated above (see n. 1), very little research has been undertaken on news photography and the contribution it makes to the construal of news values, and the most notable of this research comes from Hall (1981). According to Hall (1981: 231), the news value of the photographic sign is the elaboration of the story in terms of the professional ideology of news, which it achieves through the *connotative force* that is carried in the news photograph. What Hall is suggesting here has been theorized by Barthes (1977: 19) in terms of the denotative and connotative aspects of the photographic image. According to Barthes (1977), images exist on two levels: the first of these is the denotative level, or the goings on or happenings in the image. Denotative meanings are articulated through what is presented in the image in terms of the represented participants, the activities they are engaged in and the circumstances or locations where these activities are taking place. The other level, the connotative, is described as the art or treatment of the image. The photograph, as Barthes puts it, is ‘an object that has been worked on, chosen, composed, constructed, treated according to professional, aesthetic or ideological norms’ (1977: 19). It is this professional treatment of the image that Hall refers to as contributing to its connotative force and news value. We will explore the contributions that both denotative and connotative meanings make to the construal of news values below.

First, however, we will briefly summarize the research on news values in press photography. Hall suggests that news values in the press photograph include the unexpected, dramatic, recent event concerning a person of high status (1981: 231), while other research on news values in press photography by Craig (1994) has identified the following five news values: reference to elite persons, composition, personalization, negativity and conflict/dramatization. Craig also suggests that while press photographs can and do mostly confirm the newsworthiness of the stories they accompany, they may also perform specific functions, often in opposition to the functions of the news stories (e.g. by diverting and entertaining readers with images of people like themselves, rather than depicting the negativity of the hard news) (1994: 198).

Since we are taking a discursive approach to the construal of news values in both words and images, we will outline here some of the key aspects of news images that can construe news value. However, before we continue, it is important to acknowledge the difficulties in providing consistent image analysis. For example, it is not easy to decode the poses, gestures, facial expressions of image participants or whether a close-up, long shot, or wide angle carries the same meaning every time an image makes use of these compositional tools. A smile can signify happiness, cheek or even guilt and can thus construe both Positivity and Negativity, although a person grimacing in agony can generally be construed as Negativity. Further, a head and shoulders shot of a person may be construed as close and intimate to one reader but may be more distant and social to another. So, while the construal of news values in images might appear straightforward on the surface, it is in fact difficult to assess consistently and varies in relation to the social and cultural differences of the reader/viewer.

Following on from the above, and using our discursive approach to the construal of news values, two considerations come into play: the contextualization of the image participants, so where and with whom they are photographed and how much or how little of this is included in the image frame (the denotative aspects); and technical considerations, including shutter speed (how fast), aperture (how much light), focal length (how much in focus), lens (how distorted/natural/condensed the shot) and angle (how high or low the angle) to name but a few of these (connotative aspects). Some of these key photographic devices that can be tied to the construal of news values are described in the following.

Evaluative elements

We can evaluate image participants as important or having high status by photographing them in the middle of a media scrum with microphones and cameras pointing at them, or surrounded by bodyguards, military or a police escort, thus construing the news value of Prominence. A person photographed or filmed walking along a street flanked by lawyers/barristers could also be evaluated as important/high status, but this may be for negative reasons, if they are the defendant in a high-profile court case, so this could also construe Negativity. Uniforms and official regalia worn or carried by image participants can also indicate status and thus construe Prominence. Technical elements that could also contribute to the positive or negative evaluation of image participants include camera angle. When a photograph is taken from a very low angle (looking up towards the image participants), unequal power relations are said to be enacted between the image participants and the viewer, with the image participants said to be in the more powerful position (see Kress and van Leeuwen 2006 for further examples).⁵ This technique is commonly used to photograph politicians or military officials and may construe the news value of Prominence in the image participants.

The opposite is true when the camera angle is very high, photographing the image participants from above, and putting the viewer in a dominant position. Such an angle may construe the news value of Negativity, as it is commonly used in photographs of young offenders or prisoners of war.

Intensification

An image that serializes/repeats information in the image frame (e.g. a line of soldiers bearing arms, rather than focusing on one soldier) is a device for intensification and as such can construe Superlativeness. Similarly, photographs depicting the aftermath of natural disasters can be intensified by including many, repeated participants (e.g. several cars piled on top of each other, rather than one damaged car). Such images not only construe Impact, but also Superlativeness.

Comparison

Comparisons are also easily depicted in images by placing elements of differing sizes next to each other, again construing Superlativeness and possibly Novelty (e.g. the tallest (a basketballer) and the shortest (a gymnast) member of the Australian Commonwealth Games team photographed side-by-side). The effect of such comparisons can be further intensified and even exaggerated by manipulating technical elements in the camera: a wide-angle lens combined with a low angle perspective can exaggerate the size difference between two elements, just as a long lens combined with horizontal or high angle can condense and therefore reduce size differences.

References to emotion

Showing news actors' emotional responses in an image can construe a variety of news values, ranging from Negativity (depicting negative emotions) to Personalization (an individual's emotional response especially when combined with the use of a close-up shot), Novelty (depictions of surprise/shock in facial expressions/gestures), Impact (in terms of caused emotions) and Superlativeness (depicting strong emotional responses – very clearly seen in the desperate images of the victims of the Haiti earthquake in 2010).

An image that appears to construe several of the news values mentioned here can be seen in Figure 3.4 on p. 60. This is achieved both in the content (who has been photographed) and compositionally (how they have been captured in the frame). Superlativeness is construed by juxtaposing a single protester in the bottom right-hand corner of the frame against a whole army of riot police which fills the rest of the frame. Negativity is construed not only in this mass of riot police, but is also very clearly construed in the facial expression of the protester. Personalization is also construed in the singling out of this protestor as a representative of South Korean farmers in this protest.

Figure 3.4 An image construing the news values of Superlativeness, Negativity and Personalization ('Going against the grain', *Sydney Morning Herald*, 20 November 2004, p. 16, Fairfax Syndication)

Negative elements

The depiction of negative events (e.g. car accidents, injuries) and their effects (traffic congestion, the detritus of natural/man-made disasters) construes the news value of Negativity and/or Impact. These are, indeed, the most common of depictions in hard news photography, as photographers typically attend the scene of a disaster after it has occurred. Thus, while construing Negativity, this is commonly combined with Impact.

References to time and place

Precise references to place and, in particular, time are less easily depicted in images. Easily recognizable geographical landmarks and architecture (e.g. the White House in Washington, the Houses of Parliament in London, the Sydney Opera House) included in a shot may be used to construe Proximity (as may be cultural symbols like flags). Seasons can be depicted through the inclusion of certain typical weather conditions (snow = winter) or flora/fauna (Jacaranda blossom = spring) as well as cultural artefacts (Christmas trees) and may thus construe Timeliness, Proximity and even Consonance.

Role labels

The mere depiction of well-known (and easily recognizable) celebrities and politicians construes Prominence. However, other elites, like academics or police officers may not be so easily recognizable. Thus, the depiction of such actors/sources may be enhanced by photographing them in a particular context, for example, academics are often photographed with bookshelves around them, or a police officer may be photographed in uniform, or with the police station signage in the background.

References to individuals

In a way just including a picture of an individual construes Personalization by rendering an abstract issue more personal, especially when that individual comes to represent an entire event. However, we must be cautious in assessing every picture containing an individual as construing Personalization. As noted above, the professional elite are often quoted in the media, but this does not in itself construe Personalization. In the same way, photographing the elite acting in professional roles does not construe Personalization because it is their professional status (hence Prominence) that is emphasized in such images.

Aesthetic elements

How participants are arranged in the image frame can impact on the balance and aesthetic quality of the image (cf. Chapter 7). A 'balanced' and hence aesthetically pleasing image can construe the event as newsworthy because of its beauty. Aesthetics may thus be considered as an additional news value, at least for images. We will discuss this further in Chapter 7 but also illustrate it with an example in Section 6.

In addition to the devices mentioned above, **moving** images can also exploit other methods of construing news value. Camera shake (that causes images to blur) is rarely tolerated in still images; however, excessive movement and blurring in moving images, combined with camera people moving around, running, ducking to avoid missiles, bullets, debris with the cameras still rolling can certainly convey Negativity and Superlativeness (the extreme danger faced by the camera people). Also, the time-based nature of moving images allows the cameras to capture image sequences that may be able to convey both cause and effect, which can emphasize the consequences of an event and thereby construe Impact.

In all of these ways, then, we can see that images do, in themselves, construe newsworthiness. However, news images never appear in print alone, or without voice-over in television. In newspapers, they are always, at the very least, accompanied by a caption, and there may also be a headline and a full story associated with them. Thus, an image is influenced by the caption and other associated linguistic text and it is important to also examine how the words and images combine (see Chapter 5 for further discussion). For

Figure 3.5 ‘Bloody end to chase’, *Daily Telegraph* (Australia), 15 March 2010, p. 13, image © Newspix/Lindsay Moller

example, while an image may depict a news actor who is not culturally prominent (and so not immediately recognized as ‘elite’), the caption can bring out his/her Prominence through language, that is, by naming/identifying the news actor. Or a voice-over can add further information, for instance as to the exact speed of a rising river while showing footage of the river, how far things (or bodies) were carried by it, and so on.

Sometimes the image may be so newsworthy that it impacts on the language choices made in the text. This can be seen in Figure 3.5, where the image depicts a handcuffed bloodied man surrounded by police officers and being restrained by one of them. The blood is emphasized in the image because it was published in colour, and the profusion of blood on the man’s head and face is clearly visible. The caption to the image and the headlines are all typical in identifying the news actor and his current condition as *Hurt: The alleged offender, Bloody, arrested*, his crime (*Alleged thief*), and his capture (*chase, head-on with police car*) with the image caption also locating this incident in space and time (*in Zetland yesterday morning*). The first paragraph of the main story text reads *Bleeding profusely from a head wound, this is the dramatic moment an alleged car thief was arrested after ramming a police car in a desperate bid to get away*. The specific reference

here to the main image through the use of *this is the dramatic moment* is unusual, and demonstrates the importance of the image for construing this event as newsworthy. Linguistic resources are also usefully deployed to make this event more interesting and newsworthy (contrast the first paragraph as is with an alternative description such as *An alleged car thief tried to get away from police yesterday but had an accident and was arrested*).

6 Construing news values in discourse

In this section we will draw on the general comments that we have made above on how language and image can potentially construe news values (see also Table A1.1 in Appendix 1 for a summary table of devices in both language and image that have the potential to construe particular news values),⁶ and illustrate our discursive approach to news values by commenting on authentic examples from print news discourse. For reasons of scope, we will not discuss each news story exhaustively but rather limit our discussion to a few key points concerning the construal of newsworthiness. This means that we do not discuss all relevant news values in each news story, even though most of them include features that construe more than just one news value. Where we comment only on extracts of the story we have included them in tables (with different layout than in the original) rather than reproducing the story in full.

6.1 Timeliness

TIMELINESS – THE RELEVANCE OF THE EVENT IN TERMS OF TIME

Often construed in news discourse through: references to time, verb tense and aspect; visually through seasonal indicators (e.g. flora, environmental conditions), cultural artefacts (e.g. Easter eggs).

What the story in Table 3.5 on p. 64 clearly shows is how the verbs (*O'Donnell to address D.C. parley*, *Values Voter Summit hosting Delaware candidate for Senate*, *Christine O'Donnell will make her Washington debut*) and the reference to the near future through a premodifying nominal phrase/group (*this weekend's*) establish the Timeliness of the reported event. This is also reflected in the caption to the image (*Delaware Republican Senate nominee Christine O'Donnell will address social conservatives in Washington this weekend*), since the image itself does not construe Timeliness. The fact that

Table 3.5 ‘O’Donnell to address D.C. parley’, *Washington Times*, 17 September 2010, p. A3

Headlines and First Paragraph	Image and Caption
O’ Donnell to address D.C. parley Values Voter Summit hosting Delaware candidate for Senate BY RALPH Z. HALLOW THE WASHINGTON TIMES In a surprise move, Christine O’Donnell will make her Washington debut as the new Republican Senate candidate from Delaware at this weekend’s Values Voter Summit, the nation’s biggest annual gathering of religious and social conservatives.	Delaware Republican Senate nominee Christine O’Donnell will address social conservatives in Washington this weekend.

O’Donnell is photographed looking at something outside the image frame (and therefore not directly engaging with the viewer) may suggest that she is focused on some other place or time, thus linking it to the Timeliness that dominates the verbal text. This naturally requires analysing the image and verbal text together.

6.2 Proximity

PROXIMITY – THE GEOGRAPHICAL AND/OR CULTURAL NEARNESS OF THE EVENT

Often construed in news discourse through: references to place, references to the nation/community, first-person plural pronouns; visually in well-known or iconic landmarks, natural features or cultural symbols.

In the text in Figure 3.6 on p. 65, there are geographical references to Mexico via adjectives and proper names (*Mexican, Mexico, Tijuana*, etc.) – a country that is closer to the United States and has more relevance to it than for other countries. At the same time, the real newsworthiness in terms of Proximity is established through reference to the local community and the events in Chicago using adjectives and prepositional phrases (*local community, in Chicago* (2x), *at Pritzker Pavilion, the*

Figure 3.6 ‘A fiesta for history, the future’, *Chicago Tribune*, 13 September 2010, p. 1

Mexican community in Illinois). The story is also interesting because of the reference made to news reporting of Mexico, often revolving around a ‘drug lord from Tijuana’ – which could be discussed in terms of Consonance. The image of the street parade may also be perceived as construing Proximity since the setting – the buildings in the background – may be recognizable to a resident of Chicago, or at least to a resident of Mexican heritage who may frequent the Authentic Mexican food market in the background.

6.3 Prominence

PROMINENCE – THE HIGH STATUS OF THE INDIVIDUALS, ORGANIZATIONS OR NATIONS IN THE EVENT (INCLUDING SOURCES)

Often construed in news discourse through: evaluative language indicating importance, role labels; visually recognizable key figures, uniforms/officials, regalia, media scrum, professional contexts, low camera angle.

Table 3.6 ‘George Michael jailed for drug-driving crash’, *Guardian*, 15 September 2010, p. 3

Headlines and First Paragraph Images and Captions	
George Michael jailed for drug-driving crash as magistrate finally loses the faith Latest brush with the law leads to eight-week term Singer took prescription drug and smoked cannabis	George Michael arrives at court in London before being sentenced after admitting crashing his car while under the influence of drugs. Main image: Leon Neal/ AFP/Getty
<i>Alexandra Topping</i> George Michael, pop star, heart-throb and celebrity bad boy, is no stranger to having his collar felt by police. But yesterday the singer experienced the full weight of the law as he was sentenced to eight weeks in prison after he admitted crashing his car under the influence of cannabis.	George Michael arrives at court yesterday Top right, damage caused to the shop by the singer’s car

The Prominence of the news actor around whom the story in Table 3.6 revolves (George Michael) is established both by the use of proper names and role labels in the headlines, caption and story (*George Michael, Singer, the singer*) but also by more evaluative noun phrases: *pop star, heart-throb and celebrity bad boy*. Two images of George Michael (one mid-length shot on the front page and one with an escort on page 3) naturally construe Prominence as the singer is recognizable in both images. However, the prominent news value in all of the images in this story is Negativity. This is expressed through body language and facial expression (Michael does not appear to be posing for the camera, waving or smiling, as one would expect a celebrity to do at a promotional event), and also through the contextualization of Michael. In the first image, a police officer wearing protective armour is visible (though not in focus) in the background, and in the second image, Michael is closely flanked by a man in a suit (possibly a police officer or a solicitor) with a stern face, while construction workers

(not fans) look on in the background. The third image of a damaged wall also construes Negativity.

6.4 Consonance

CONSONANCE – THE STEREOTYPICAL ASPECTS OF AN EVENT

Often construed in news discourse through: evaluative language indicating expectedness, repeated word combinations, conventionalized metaphors, story structure, comparison; visual representations that fit with the stereotypical imagery of an event/person.

Figure 3.7 ‘Berlusconi’s pep talk to the gold diggers of the world’, *Globe and Mail*, 14 September 2010, p. A2. Used with permission of the Associated Press
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The story in Figure 3.7 centres on Berlusconi, arguably construing Consonance by focusing on his quotes about women (e.g. *Berlusconi's pep talk to the gold diggers of the world; Italian Premier Silvio Berlusconi says young women should follow the money when looking for a partner noting that women seem to like him and 'I'm loaded'*), while at the same time including references to and comparisons with past behaviour that make clear that this is very much in line with expectations and with what others think (*was embroiled in a sex scandal last year and is known for his gaffes; a much-criticized TV interview he once gave; was engulfed in a sex scandal last year centring on his purported dalliances with young women*). It is interesting to compare this story with extracts from a background or feature story on Berlusconi in the *Sydney Morning Herald* where evaluations of expectedness (*legendary, notorious, of course*) and comparisons (*once again, yet another, this time/in this case, always a twist to such stories*) similarly construe Consonance in terms of Berlusconi and women (bold face ours):

The Prime Minister [Berlusconi] himself accuses his opponents of exploiting uncertainty and deliberately pushing the nation to an early election at a time of austerity – rhetoric that sounds particularly hollow from a man whose love of luxury and lavish parties is **legendary**.

AS IF Berlusconi did not have enough on this plate just days before this defining movement for his leadership and legacy, WikiLeaks – and **yet another** personal scandal – erupted, catapulting him and his **notorious** wandering gaze **once again** on to domestic and world front pages.

...

However, attractive young women feature **once again** this week, landing Berlusconi in the sights of the national court of auditors, **this time** amid allegations that he allowed the use of nearly €400,000 in state funds to fly a Bulgarian director-actress and a large entourage to the Venice Film Festival.

Of course as veteran Berlusconi watchers have come to realise, there is **always a twist to such stories**, and in **this case** claims have emerged that Berlusconi also personally ordered that an award be created for the pretty 39-year-old director, Michelle Bonev, who was reported to have received an “action for women” prize for her film, *Goodbye Mama*. (‘Embattled Berlusconi faces his nemesis’, *Sydney Morning Herald, News Review*, 11–12 December 2010, pp. 20–1)

It seems clear that there are associations (negative ones, we would argue) of Berlusconi's behaviour, specifically with regard to (young) women, that are played to and at the same time construed or built up in such news discourse.

While the news story in the *Globe and Mail* does not include an image, images can clearly construe Consonance. A good example can be found in the reporting of seasonal events or cultural festivals and, in particular,

Figure 3.8 Online news gallery image sequence, depicting typical scenes at the *Oktoberfest* in Munich, Germany ('Oktoberfest starts in Munich', www.guardian.co.uk, 21 September 2009)

in the reporting of cultural events occurring in other countries, as the typical, indeed stereotypical, is often what is emphasized in such reporting. Figure 3.8 above is an extract from an online news gallery from www.guardian.co.uk and concerns the festivities at the *Oktoberfest* in Munich, Germany. As can be seen in Figure 3.8, beer, breasts and traditional costumes are the focus of attention and a not at all surprising selection from a British news organization (see Chapter 5 for further discussion of this gallery in terms of text–image relations).

6.5 Negativity

NEGATIVITY – THE NEGATIVE ASPECTS OF AN EVENT

Often construed in news discourse through: negative evaluative language, references to negative emotions, negative vocabulary; visual representations of negative events and their effects, showing people's negative emotions, high camera angle, camera movement/blurring.

In Figure 3.9 on pp. 70–1 there are actually three articles grouped together under a common heading (*Gang wars*) and headline ('Dissident quizzed over murder of criminal') but we will only comment on one of them ('10 suspects arrested hours after cold-blooded shooting'). In this story, we can easily find many examples of both evaluative language (some attributed to sources) and negative vocabulary that build up a lexical field of criminals, violent crime and victims, and thereby construe Negativity, for instance:

Gang wars, murder, murder victim, criminal, cold-blooded shooting, victim, shooting, offences, illegal, gangland criminals, extortion racket, critically injured, crime gang, shot in the head, attacker, injured, attacks, killer, gunman, grim task, dead, cold-blooded assassination, depressing reality, tough anti-gang legislation . . .

Figure 3.9 'Dissident quizzed over murder of criminal', *Irish Independent*, 14 September 2010, pp. 4–5

Figure 3.9 *Continued*

Focusing on the main picture on page 4, Negativity is construed in the tape used to cordon off the area (restricting access) and the blue covering (shielding onlookers from the scene). This is also a very long shot, taken with a powerful zoom lens, suggesting that the event is so serious/grave that even the media cannot get access. The white suited figures of the forensic team are commonly seen at crime scenes, adding to the construal of Negativity.

6.6 Impact

IMPACT – THE EFFECTS OR CONSEQUENCES OF AN EVENT

Often construed in news discourse through: evaluative language and intensification/quantification relating to the impact of an event, references to emotions caused by an event, references to effects/impact on individuals, entities, and so on; visually showing the after-effects of events, sequences of images conveying cause–effect relations.

Figure 3.10 ‘Firefighters contain industrial blaze’, *New Zealand Herald*, 13 October 2010, p. A6

News stories frequently focus on the impact of events. In the story represented in Figure 3.10 on p. 72 this is construed through intensification/quantification as well as references focusing on the effects of the fire: for example, *industrial blaze, up to 12 fire appliances, engulfed, totally alight, adjacent buildings needed to be evacuated*. The photograph of the damaged shed is typical of aftermath images and clearly construes the news value of Impact. Professional photographers are rarely in a position to photograph the causes of accidents, explosions, disasters, but do frequently capture the consequences. This is transitioning though, with more and more people carrying mobile devices that can capture images of sufficient quality. News organizations do publish such images of the unfolding of major incidents, both natural and man-made, which are captured by eyewitnesses, or even by the victims themselves.

An example of how environmental stories are frequently construed in terms of Impact (cf. also Bednarek and Caple 2010) comes from the front page of the popular newspaper *New York Post* (Figure 3.11).

Figure 3.11 'Wild', *New York Post*, 17 September 2010, p. 1

Here again intensifications of force and evaluative language (*savage, hammers, wild, killer storm, tore, 100-mph winds, jungle*) as well as more descriptive references to the storm's negative effects (*toppled trees*) focus on the impact of the environmental event. The typography and exclamation mark reinforces the intensification of the **wild** storm and its impact. News values of Impact (and Superlativeness) are thus construed through the language. Damage to property (cars) is clearly depicted in the image in Figure 3.11 thus construing Impact, and similar to the verbal text, the image also construes Superlativeness, as this is not only damage to one car but three (and possibly more beyond the frame). This is enhanced technically through the use of a wide angle lens that fills the frame with branches and leaves. In fact, the story from the *New York Post* suggests that the use of devices that establish the news value of Superlativeness may be especially significant in the popular press. Conboy (2006: 16) notes the frequent use of extremes, exaggeration and hyperbole in such newspapers, all of which may be used to construe Superlativeness.

6.7 Novelty/deviance/unusuality/rarity/surprise

NOVELTY – THE UNEXPECTED ASPECTS OF AN EVENT

Often construed in news discourse through: evaluative language indicating unexpectedness, comparison, references to surprise/expectations; visually in the juxtaposition of elements within the frame to create stark contrast, the depiction of shock/surprise in the facial expression of participants.

The story in Table 3.7 (on p. 75) construes Novelty in a variety of ways: the headline simply describes what audiences would view as an unusual event, without explicitly evaluating it as such (but construing Personalization by using what seems to be a direct quote). Negations, evaluative adjectives and intensification also construe this unexpectedness, including: *doesn't speak French. It just sounds as if she does; has only ever been to France twice and hasn't spoken the language since taking her O-levels, rare condition, strange, so rare that there are just 60 recorded cases*. However, the portrait image of the news actor in this story does not construe Novelty. Indeed, it is difficult to match this image with any news values other than Personalization.

But in the example in Figure 3.12 (on p. 75), the news value of Novelty is clearly construed through the depiction of a naked (save his trilby) farmer at the wheel of a tractor and a naked vet posing with a turkey – all in a good cause!

Table 3.7 'I went to bed with a migraine and woke up with a French accent', *Daily Mail*, 15 September 2010, p. 19

Headline and First Paragraphs	Image and Caption
I went to bed with a migraine and woke up with a French accent <i>By Luke Salkeld</i> [email provided] KAY Russell doesn't speak French. It just sounds as if she does. As soon as she opens her mouth the 49-year-old grandmother gives the impression she grew up on the other side of the Channel. She has foreign accent syndrome, a rare condition thought to have been caused by damage to her brain after a series of migraines. Mrs Russell, who lives in Gloucestershire, went to bed one day with a particularly painful headache and woke to find her speech was 'strange and slurred'. An MRI scan ordered by a hospital neurologist indicated the headache had inflicted a mild form of brain damage. She was then diagnosed with FAS – a condition so rare that there are just 60 recorded cases worldwide. Yesterday Mrs Russell, who has only ever been to France twice and hasn't spoken the language since taking her O-levels, said having no control over speaking so differently had destroyed her self-confidence.	Kay Russell: 'You lose your identity' [cartoon omitted]

Figure 3.12 'Calendar boys Businessmen bare all for charity', *Irish Independent*, 11 October 2010, p. 14

6.8 Superlativeness

SUPERLATIVENESS – THE MAXIMIZED OR INTENSIFIED ASPECTS OF AN EVENT

Often construed in news discourse through: intensification/quantification, comparison, references to strong emotions, metaphor, simile; visually construed through the repetition of elements in the frame, or extreme emotions in participants, use of wide-angle lens.

Consider this extract from a story in *USA Today*:

Record rise in U.S. uninsured: 50.7 M
Numbers reignite debate over health care law
By Richard Wolf USA TODAY

[direct quote preceding main story text omitted]

A record rise in the number of people without health insurance across the nation is fuelling renewed debate over a health care law that could to [sic] work better at boosting coverage than controlling costs.

More than 50 million people were uninsured last year, almost one in six U.S. residents, the Census Bureau reported Thursday. The percentage with private insurance was the lowest since the government began keeping data in 1987.

The reasons for the rise to 50.7 million, or 16.7%, from 46.3 million uninsured, or 15.4%, were many: . . .

(‘Record rise in U.S. uninsured: 50.7 M’, *USA Today*, 17 September 2010, p. A8)

This extract features a variety of expressions that construe Superlativeness at the beginning of the article, mainly intensification/quantification and comparison: *record rise*; *more than 50 million people*; *almost one in six U.S. residents*; *the lowest since the government began keeping data*; *the rise to 50.7 million*.

Images can construe Superlativeness through the depiction of excessive emotion. In the example in Figure 3.13, the image participant is completely overwhelmed at the news of the imminent release of loved ones from the Chilean mine disaster in October 2010. The sense of movement and use of a wide-angle lens contribute to the intensification of this emotional reaction.

Figure 3.13 'Miners vie to be last man out as rescue tests begin', *Irish Independent*, 11 October 2010, p. 28

6.9 Personalization

PERSONALIZATION – THE PERSONAL OR HUMAN INTEREST ASPECTS OF AN EVENT

Often construed in news discourse through: references to emotion, quotes from 'ordinary' people, references to individuals; visually by singling out one participant in the frame, depicting emotions, close-up shot.

The construal of Personalization is strong in Figure 3.14 on p. 79 from the *Ottawa Sun*. This is clearly visible in the use of an extreme close-up shot of the victim on the front page, with the black background bleeding into both the image and the words. The headline points to Personalization in that *Tragic Case of Elder Abuse* together with the subheadline (*EXCLUSIVE: Dorothy Linklater, 92, lost her life savings, her home and her dignity*) and the image construe this news story as one about a particular case and person. The story continues on page 3 with the heading *Nieces Save Aunt from Fraudster* and the subheading *92-year-old's life savings frittered away by 'caregiver'*, continuing the construal in terms of personal relationships (*Nieces, Aunt*) and the focus on the *92-year-old* and her exploitation by the *fraudster*, with the story starting with an attribution of Dorothy Linklater's wishes and plans and how they were thwarted:

Dorothy Linklater never wanted to be a burden on her family. And at 92 she hadn't planned to come back to Ottawa. She left her hometown in the 1950s for southern Ontario, and after her husband died 30 years ago that's where she intended to live out her final days. The pair never had children of their own. But those plans have been dashed at the hands of a live-in caregiver who fleeced Linklater of her entire life savings, home and dignity.

The news actor is also identified both through proper names (*Dorothy Linklater, Linklater*), reference to age (*92, 92-year-old's, at 92*), and reference to kinship relations (*aunt, the pair*). This is reinforced in the image, where the intimate moment of one person holding and kissing the other is captured. Fowler notes that '[t]he concreteness of individual reference is heightened, especially in the tabloids, by supplying personal details such as age, residence, job and personal appearance – with a liberal use of photographs' (Fowler 1991: 92). The story also includes direct quotes from one of the nieces and the aunt herself as well as references to their emotions (*shocking, tears welled up in her eyes, it crushed my heart*). In fact, this is an example where Personalization is not about showing

Figure 3.14 ‘Tragic case of elder abuse’, *Ottawa Sun*, 12 November 2010, pp. 1, 3

how an abstract issue affects individuals, but rather a news story about one person's negative experience (with a strong construal of Negativity as well as Personalization). Indeed, Personalization has been said to be 'most striking in the popular press', working 'to promote straightforward feelings of identification, empathy or disapproval' (Fowler 1991: 15) and from a critical perspective to avoid a discussion of more complex underlying socio-economic factors (Fowler 1991: 16).

6.10 *Aesthetics*

Sometimes, an event is construed as beautiful or aesthetically noteworthy and therefore newsworthy, as in the story on 'Deer' in Figure 3.15 on p. 81 – an example of a stand-alone (also theorized as an image-nuclear news story (Caple 2008a, 2008b, 2009b)). The aesthetic quality of the image, along with the ability to make a pun between the headline and the image (see Chapter 4 on headlines) make this event newsworthy and the story worthy of a position on the front page. In fact the 'news story' is not essentially about the deer pictured, rather it is about the cold snap gripping Britain at that time, which is alluded to in the caption and then reported on in full on page 4. Thus, we argue that an event can be construed as newsworthy by construing it as aesthetically significant (e.g. beautiful) and therefore of news value. This is in contrast to language, where aesthetic aspects of language as they occur in poems, for instance, are not in line with the conventions of the hard news story – compare Chapter 4. (This may be different with more 'narrative', 'feature' or 'soft' news, where there is more freedom in terms of linguistic style (Bell 1991: 14) and where we might find some 'aesthetic' uses of language.)

In this chapter, we have taken a discursive approach to news values and have introduced a framework that allows for analysis of how these are construed in both words and images. From this perspective, news values are not aspects of events or internalized beliefs; they are values that are established by language and image in use. Such a discursive perspective allows researchers to systematically examine how particular events are construed as newsworthy, what values are emphasized in news stories, and how language and image establish events as more or less newsworthy. There is great potential here for comparative studies. It is only through a systematic analysis of both modalities – language and image – and how they contribute to the construction of news discourse that we can gain a fuller understanding of how events are retold and made 'newsworthy'. Then we may begin to also understand the motivations behind maximizing news value, which can include the journalist's (and photographer's) desire for a front page story, or commercial functions such as selling more copies (increasing circulation) or attracting particular kinds of audience that can be sold to advertisers (cf. Chapter 2).

Figure 3.15 ‘Oh deer, it’s turned out cold again’, *Daily Telegraph* (UK), 17 December 2010, p. 1

Directions for further reading

- Bednarek, M. (2006), *Evaluation in Media Discourse: Analysis of a Newspaper Corpus*. London/New York: Continuum. A book-length investigation of evaluative language and its functions (including news values) in the British popular and quality press.
- Bell, A. (1991), *The Language of News Media*. Oxford: Blackwell. Includes a discussion of copy editing and linguistic characteristics of news stories in terms of news values.
- Brighton, P. and Foy, D. (2007), *News Values*. London: Sage. Applies the concept of news values to the online environment.
- Craig, G. (1994), 'Press photographs and news values', *Australian Studies in Journalism*, 3, 182–200. Applies news values to press photography.
- Galtung, J. and Ruge, M. H. (1965), 'The structure of foreign news', *Journal of Peace Research*, 2 (1) 64–91. The classic study of news values, focusing on Scandinavian news.
- Hall, S. (1981), 'The determinations of news photographs', in S. Cohen and J. Young (eds), *The Manufacture of News. Deviance, Social Problems and the Mass Media*. London: Sage, pp.226–43. The classic study of news values in press photography.
- Niblock, S. and Machin, D. (2007), 'News values for consumer groups: the case of Independent Radio News, London, UK', *Journalism*, 8 (2), 184–204. Addresses the relation between news values, market segmentation and the packaging of commercial radio news bulletins.

Notes

- 1 Not only do lists of news values differ in the number and kinds of news values recognized, news values have also been grouped differently, for example, depending on whether or not they are culture-free or culture-bound (Galtung and Ruge 1965) and how important or 'core' they are (Conley 1997). More recently, Brighton and Foy (2007) have proposed a new set of news values that reflect recent changes in the news media landscape. However, most of this research does not address press photography (for exceptions see Hall 1981, Craig 1994 and Caple 2009b).
- 2 Researchers who work with a more 'cognitive' definition of news values also emphasize the role language plays, with news values being said to be 'embedded' in text or shaping text (e.g. Cotter 2010: 67), especially news story structure. Cotter (2010: 95–7) also gives some examples of how news values are construed in story meeting exchanges. Language is also relevant to some of the *news cycle/market factors*. For instance, composition can be signalled through the use of common headings where there are spreads on specific topics such as WikiLeaks and stories grouped under such common headings will also share some common vocabulary, from the same semantic field. In fact, there may even be a case for including composition under our category of news values (rather than a news cycle/market factor) because it can be discursively construed.

- 3 *Just* has a range of different meanings and can express both intensification (e.g. *just hours after*) and concession (e.g. *He's just a student*). It would not construe Superlativeness in the latter meaning. There are various linguistic classifications for intensification and quantification that provide further detail on relevant linguistic devices (e.g. Hood and Martin 2007).
- 4 Comparison, intensification and references to emotion could also be included as part of evaluative language or appraisal (Martin and White 2005). Also note that evaluative language has many additional functions apart from construing news value (cf. Hunston and Thompson 2000, Martin and White 2005, Bednarek 2006c). The distinction between evaluative and non-evaluative language is sometimes hard to draw, although there are grammatical tests, for instance, for evaluative adjectives (Halliday and Matthiessen 2004: 319). Compare also the discussion of evaluation in Chapter 6.
- 5 Other research that has examined evaluative meaning in images includes Economou (2006) and Martin and Rose (2007), although this has not been in relation to the construal of news values.
- 6 Table A1.1 in Appendix 1 takes as its starting point news values and how they may potentially be construed through language and image; Table 3.4 in this chapter summarizes the potential of linguistic resources only. Depending on research question and focus either one or both can be drawn on.